

*Illustration by* SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

# TRUSTED LIEUTENANT

Assam CM **Himanta Biswa Sarma's** rapport with Union home minister **Amit Shah** is no secret, and its influence was clear in the recent election for the general secretary's post at the all-powerful Indian cricket body, BCCI. The position, vacated by Amit Shah's son **Jay Shah** after his ascension as International Cricket Council (ICC) chairman, demanded a trusted successor. Enter **Devajit Saikia**, former BCCI joint secretary under Shah Jr, who was elected unopposed. A former Ranji player and wicketkeeper for Assam, Saikia also serves as the state's advocate general. Less widely known is the fact that he and Sarma have been buddies since childhood. This relationship, coupled with Saikia's reputation for being discreet and meticulous—traits Shah Jr values—cements his place in the intricate web of power connecting cricket and politics.



ANI

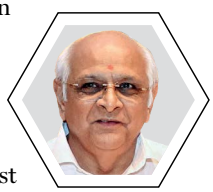
## Didi Maange More

With **Mamata Banerjee,** "some" just doesn't cut it. When the Bengal CM recently voiced her frustration over the dwindling number of buses in Kolkata, transport minister Snehashis Chakraborty meekly cited an increase in "*kichhu* (some) frequency". Mamata, never one for half-measures, shot back, declaring that "some" meant nothing at all. She also told Chakraborty to hit the streets to learn first-hand the commuters' woes. This wasn't Mamata's first flare-up over the city's transport woes. Back in August, she had fumed about night service buses doing the vanishing act.

**Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amarnath K. Menon, Jumana Shah and Avishek G. Dastidar**

## Treasure Trade

Gujarat CM **Bhupendra Patel**'s *tosha-khana*—a treasure trove of gifts received during his tenure—has turned into an online shopping extravaganza. Items up for e-auction range from opulent pieces, like a gold-and-silver-plated glass set (Rs 5 lakh), a silver mace (Rs 2.95 lakh), to a modest straw Ganesh miniature (Rs 1,900). Launched in October 2024, the auction has in just three months collected Rs 74 lakh from the sale of 427 items; Rs 37 lakh from this goes to the Kanya Kelavani scheme, promoting education for girls.



## BLAST FROM THE PAST



A long-forgotten paper by **Hitendra Malhotra**, now the first non-IRTS (Indian Railway Traffic Service) officer to head the Railway Board's traffic vertical, is back in the news. Written when he was a young additional divisional railway manager in Moradabad, the paper proposed reforms and had comments like: '...headquarters conducts long conferences 2-3 times daily. This leaves divisional officers with little time to think and plan....'; 'Traffic inspectors are utilised more in protocol duties, leaving less time for rigorous inspections.' Will Malhotra follow his own prescriptions now?



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

## Marks and the Man

Telangana CM **A. Revanth Reddy** greeted visitors in the new year with more than the usual pleasantries. Cabinet colleagues and MLAs bearing bouquets found themselves facing a reality check: performance appraisals. Reddy disclosed that annual evaluations had been conducted, and that he planned to share the results so they could address shortcomings—just as he pledged to tackle his own, based on his own report card. The grading system underscores his reputation as a no-nonsense taskmaster, a leader who rose to the top without prior ministerial experience. It's also the perfect reason for a possible cabinet reshuffle—simply point to the report card.